

Living With Dignity

Once dedicated to goddess Yellamma and forced into sex work, the former devadasis of Bagalkot are chalking out a new destiny for themselves and their children with help from support groups



Photographs by JIPESH G

■ By Stephen David

Satyavathy Madar, 34, looks stunning. Clad in a pink sari, with her prominent cheekbones and penetrating eyes, she could pass for a business executive. She has gathered 15 women for a meeting at a small house in Kaladige village in Bagalkot district of north Karnataka, to discuss their finances—how to meet their individual expenses and arrange the marriages of their children.

Satyavathy and her ilk were brought up as devadasis—female servants of the Lord, dedicated to Yellamma, the Hindu goddess of fertility, and used for sex with religious sanction. They are now charting a different life for themselves, proving to the world that they can be economically independent and socially relevant. Satyavathy, now a mother of two school-going children, remembers how she was dedicated to Yellamma at puberty. “It was considered an acceptable religious custom here,” she says,

Devadasis were originally temple girls who participated in rituals where

they displayed their singing and dancing skills. In the name of service to God, they were almost always initiated into prostitution. The devadasi system was outlawed way back during the British Raj and later, the state government clamped the practice, making it punishable under the Karnataka Devadasi Prohibition Act, 1982. Yet, it continues to thrive in remote parts of north Karnataka. “Sadly, families felt they were sacrificing their daughters to God,” says Karnataka State Women’s Commission chief Pramila Nesargi. Most of the women, however, ended up as harlots. Marevva Madar, 32, one of the many poor dalit women who got sucked into the system, says, “We had hoped for material prosperity when we were offered to goddess Yellamma.”

NGOs and support groups like the Karnataka Health Promotion Trust

REWRITING THEIR FATE: Former devadasis attending a night school

(KHPT) have been working for rehabilitation and empowerment of former devadasis—there are about 10,000 in the state—in Bijapur and Bagalkot districts. “We have taught them to take charge of their destiny. It is a paradigm shift in the management of their lives,” says KHPT Executive Director Vandana Gurnani, an IAS officer who has taken a break from her bureaucratic work to help these women. “Thanks to social welfare groups who taught us to stand on our own feet, we can now live a

dignified life,” says Satyavathy. There are about 200 mahila sanghas in Bagalkot, each having 20-odd volunteers, whose basic expenses are taken care of by KHPT.

Twenty-six-year-old Madhu Nadvinmane lost her parents when she was eight and was dedicated to a temple by her elder

Devadasis are now proving to the world that they can be independent and socially relevant.